Robinson Crusoe, the Enlightenment, and the Modern Individual

A New Hero for a New Age

Robinson Crusoe is sometimes dismissed as an insubstantial adventure story, suitable for adolescents but lacking literary depth. I want to argue against that judgment. Daniel Defoe's novel is one of the first great English novels, and, more importantly for this discussion, it offers a way of understanding the Enlightenment. It epitomizes how Western European culture at the beginning of the eighteenth century looked at nature and the rest of the world.

To encapsulate an entire intellectual tendency in a work of fiction is a considerable achievement, whatever crudities we may find in the plot or difficulties in the diction. One way of approaching Robinson Crusoe is therefore to regard it as the construction of a new hero for a new time. Published in 1719, it belongs to a period when English commercial capitalism was a growing economic force and wealth was transforming social relations.

This changing society raised new questions: How would human beings relate to one another? How would they relate to nature? How should they understand their new condition? The Homeric hero embodies something of ancient Greek society and its conception of virtue. The otherworldly saint, or the strenuous pursuit of Christian virtue represented in the morality play Everyman, offers a corresponding image of the medieval ideal. Crusoe supplies a different model: Enlightenment man.

I use "man" deliberately here, because the individual represented in this novel is specifically male. The significance of that choice will become clearer when we consider the place of women and the family. For now, two fundamental themes help to place Crusoe in the context of the Enlightenment: the domination of nature and the relationship between Western culture and other cultures.

The Enlightenment, especially in the late seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, grew out of the scientific transformations of the seventeenth century. Newtonian mechanics and modern natural science were foundational to its thought. Social theory, political philosophy, and literature responded to a new relationship with nature: knowledge appeared to make it possible to manipulate the natural world for human purposes. This project of domination is also central to Crusoe's life on the island.

The second theme concerns non-Western cultures. The Enlightenment followed the age of exploration and depended on advances in science and technology. European exploration and economic exploitation brought encounters with societies unfamiliar with Christianity and organized around very different understandings of nature and social life. How would Western Europeans conceive of these others, whom they often called "savages"? Crusoe dramatizes that problem and some of its possible responses.

My argument is that Crusoe's growing command of nature and of the people he encounters forms an allegory of Western culture's relationship with the wider world. He passes through stages of technological and cultural development as an individual rather than as a society. The shipwreck seems to place him in the "state of nature," a central

concept in Enlightenment political theory. Yet he does not truly begin from nothing: the European tools he salvages are essential to his survival.

In the Republic, Plato draws an analogy between the individual and the city. Something comparable is at work here: Crusoe's development, his use of reason, and his mastery of nature become an image of a larger cultural process. His process is, in that sense, our process. He is a hero of productivity, prudence, and diligence—qualities that do not ordinarily sound heroic. It is difficult to imagine Achilles ploughing a field.

It is equally difficult to imagine a great Christian mystic chiefly concerned with growing barley and rice. Jesus says: "My kingdom is not of this world." Crusoe, by contrast, inhabits a thoroughly practical world. He has a frightening dream, but his life is not dominated by ecstatic visions. His concerns are food, shelter, tools, and the prudent organization of work. At the same time, his increasingly religious outlook cannot be separated from those material concerns.

Crusoe is relentlessly acquisitive, and this makes the novel a revealing image of English commercial society. Marx later challenged the use of isolated figures like Crusoe as models for political economy, making the novel's individualism important to later economic debate. Crusoe joins two foundational traditions of Western culture, often symbolized by Athens and Jerusalem: rational mastery and biblical religion. Their alliance is uneasy, and the plot repeatedly reveals its tensions.

Rousseau's educational work Émile gives Robinson Crusoe an exceptional place. At a stage when the pupil is to be protected from the corrupting influence of books, this is the one book he may read. Rousseau sees it as a means of learning to judge necessities, work, and self-sufficiency. My suspicion is that its appeal also lies in how it concentrates important tendencies of Western culture while excluding much that might distract or mislead a young reader.

This is therefore more than an adventure story for adolescent boys. A reader returning to it in adulthood may discover a very different book. Its philosophical significance becomes clearer when we examine its characters and the structure of its plot. Unlike War and Peace or Cervantes's fiction, it has a relatively small cast, and a few central relationships carry much of the argument.

God, Providence, and Economic Man

The most important presence in the novel is God. This may sound strange, because God does not appear as an ordinary speaking character. He is, as it were, the strong, silent type: always present, governing the world providentially. As Crusoe develops, his relationship with God changes. He becomes something like Job, a servant who tries to accept what providence brings and reconcile himself to the justice of God's purposes.

Christianity has a long and varied history, and Christians have imagined their relationship with the divine in very different ways. Think of the ecstatic illumination of the mystical tradition, of Teresa of Ávila in the sixteenth century, or of Pascal's seventeenth-century "night of fire." Such experiences suggest an immediate, powerful apprehension of the divine. Crusoe's characteristic religious experience has a markedly different emphasis.

His God is practical and useful: a God who sends necessities and rewards diligence, prudence, and hard work. In the satirical terms of this reading, he resembles a celestial foreman, supervising labour. When Crusoe recognizes providence, its sign may be barley

or rice. The accidental sprouting of grain receives an extended, almost rhapsodic treatment. For Crusoe, agricultural provision can become evidence that God is attending to his life.

This is a very worldly way of understanding providence. One might ask, somewhat uncharitably, whether Crusoe would be as religious if God did not give him useful things. The point is not that he has no inward spiritual life, but that his religious interpretation repeatedly connects divine care with material provision. He comes to believe that God supervises his circumstances and that the punishments he has suffered are deserved consequences of his wrongdoing.

Here Crusoe's God differs from the inscrutable God of Job. Job's suffering cannot be explained simply as punishment for a specific sin; the inadequacy of such explanations is part of the book's force. Crusoe invokes Job, but often supposes that he can identify the moral reason for his own misfortunes. God has chastised him because he is sinful. Providence becomes, up to a point, comprehensible and predictable.

The problem is theodicy: how to reconcile the existence of evil and suffering with a just and good God. It is important in English literature at least since Milton, and in the biblical tradition since Job. Crusoe's contribution frequently takes a practical, material form. His useful God assists with agriculture, explains misfortune through sin, and rewards the person who eventually learns the proper lesson.

The second central figure is Crusoe himself, and I find him in many respects unattractive. He can be read as an early literary embodiment of what later came to be called homo economicus, economic man. Crusoe lives to acquire and consume. He even collects things with little immediate use, as though acquisition were a purpose in its own right.

Imagine the caricature of an Englishman whose thoughts revolve around getting and consuming things, and you have one way of understanding him. Hobbes's account of human beings as mechanisms pursuing their desires supplies another comparison. Crusoe tries to satisfy his wants through his encounters with nature, and he organizes his life accordingly. He is not a disinterested observer of the world: he continually asks what can be made useful.

Yet a purely economic or Hobbesian account is insufficient. Crusoe is economic man burdened with profound religious anxiety. He must not only acquire things but also justify himself and understand why God treats him as he does. God's existence is never seriously doubted. Guilt, sin, and misgivings about his moral condition accompany him from the beginning, even when he knowingly does wrong.

His decision to go to sea against his father's advice becomes what he later calls his "original sin." The allegory is transparent. At the same time, his relationships often seem emotionally restricted. It would be inaccurate to say that he never feels fear, grief, despair, or loneliness; the novel contains these feelings. Nevertheless, the prominence of calculation, work, and religious self-examination can make ordinary human attachment seem surprisingly peripheral.

He spends twenty-eight years on the island, much of that time alone, before Friday and the other arrivals transform his circumstances. His journal repeatedly concerns sowing fields, domesticating goats, conserving resources, and organizing labour. The two dominant subjects are his relationship with nature and his relationship with God. His

practical achievements accompany the conviction that he has finally understood his sins and repented of them.

Sexual desire and romantic love occupy little space in this account. When he eventually marries, his wife remains unnamed and scarcely developed as a character. They have children, but family life is compressed into a brief report. He remains in England for years, and it is after her death that he travels again. Even so, the marginal treatment of marriage leaves us knowing remarkably little about this part of his life.

Crusoe talks far more about commerce than about falling in love. In this respect he can seem almost a parody of the perfect Enlightenment figure: rationalist, empiricist, and manipulator of nature, with emotional life subordinate to other concerns. He is very unlike Stendhal's Julien Sorel, whose ambitions are inseparable from intense personal feeling. Crusoe's restraint raises questions about what this model of the individual includes and what it excludes.

The Other, Slavery, and Colonial Power

A third central figure is not so much a single person as a recurring type: the "savage." I use this word to describe the novel's colonial categories, not to endorse them. From the perspective of imperial Europe, the world could be divided into "us" and "them." The people placed in the second category are often given less individuality than the European who interprets them. Their significance depends largely on their relation to his purposes.

In a deliberately polemical reading, there are two kinds: the "good savage" and the "bad savage." Friday represents the first. He is willing to learn Christianity, serve Crusoe, and enter an unequal economic relationship with him. The good native is the tractable, educable person who can be incorporated into European arrangements. His gratitude for rescue becomes entangled with acceptance of subordination.

The threatening cannibals represent the opposite category: people whose practices seem to justify violent resistance or destruction. Taken in this stark form, the distinction resembles the logic used to defend slavery, colonial oppression, imperialism, and even the extermination of populations. Those who submit may be exploited; those who do not are represented as deserving elimination. This is a criticism of colonial representation, not a factual claim about non-European peoples.

The historical setting matters. This is an English novel published in 1719, amid the expansion of commercial and colonial power. Its island is a microcosm of European relations with nature and other societies. The contrast is not the whole story: Crusoe also questions his right to kill people merely for following their own customs, and the cast includes more than these two types. Nevertheless, the hierarchy between master and dependent remains central.

Departure, Disobedience, and the Fall

A historical biological formula can serve as a metaphor for the plot: "ontogeny recapitulates phylogeny." It proposed that the development of an individual repeats the evolutionary history of the species. This is not an accepted literal law of modern biology. A human embryo does not pass through a series of complete ancestral animals, nor does

it develop functioning fish gills. The old formula is useful here only as an analogy for cultural development.

In Crusoe’s case, one person appears to reconstruct the history of civilization. Expelled from ordinary society, he must return to basic needs and rebuild a way of life. This makes his experience more than a sequence of adventures. The relationship between individual development and collective development gives the plot its philosophical unity, even where particular incidents seem repetitive, contrived, or clumsy.

At the beginning, his father advises him to stay at home and live in the middle station of life. He need not aspire to aristocratic grandeur or expose himself to poverty. A comfortable existence is available without dangerous wandering. In the allegorical reading, the father resembles God the Father, and the secure home resembles Eden. England becomes, as it were, the garden from which the son chooses to depart.

Crusoe disobeys, and the departure becomes a version of the Fall. Later he explicitly interprets this choice as his original sin. Defoe’s symbolism can be heavy-handed, and he often reinforces an idea through repetition. The early English novel was still developing its characteristic forms, although prose fiction certainly did not begin in 1719. We should recognize these formal limitations without overlooking the force of the allegory.

Once he goes to sea, a terrible storm supplies another warning. The ship’s master interprets the disaster providentially and urges him to abandon the sea. Crusoe returns to land, but soon finds another opportunity to sail. In his later religious interpretation, this is stubborn pride and wilfulness: an insistence on having his own way despite both paternal counsel and divine warning. Put simply, it is sin.

The broad pattern is disobedience, punishment, recognition, repentance, and eventual deliverance. This structure makes the spiritual allegory quite clear. But the worldly motives are equally important. Crusoe goes trading on the African coast because he wants to acquire wealth. European goods can be exchanged for more valuable commodities, including gold, and a successful voyage encourages another. Having made money, he wants to make still more.

This can be compared with the movement Marx later describes as M–C–M′: money is exchanged for commodities, which are sold for an increased sum of money. Crusoe repeatedly returns to the circuit of accumulation. Ironically, he approaches the comfortable middle station his father had recommended, but only through the risks that the father had told him to avoid. His progress is then interrupted when pirates from Salé capture and enslave him.

The novel identifies these captors with a Muslim setting. The contrast with the Christian European protagonist contributes to its ethnocentric perspective. It would be wrong, however, to infer that piracy belonged only to Muslims or that Christian wrongdoers have no place in the story: English mutineers later play an important role. The point concerns the moral arrangement of this episode, in which Crusoe becomes the victim of the coercion he will later inflict on others.

Xury, Brazil, and the Slave Voyage

Crusoe devises an escape when he is sent fishing in a boat supplied with food, water, and weapons. He leaves with the boy Xury, who helps him, and they travel along the West African coast. They meet people who provide assistance and others whom Crusoe fears. His interpretation of these encounters continues to sort strangers according to their usefulness or their apparent threat to his survival.

A Portuguese captain rescues them and takes them toward Brazil. He is represented as a good and generous man, although he is Catholic rather than Protestant. The episode therefore allows a degree of tolerance within Christianity. Crusoe wants to pay for his passage, as a conscientious businessman should, but the captain refuses to charge him. He does, however, offer to purchase Xury.

Crusoe has qualms about selling the boy who helped him regain his freedom. He has himself been enslaved, and he knows what loss of liberty means. Nevertheless, he accepts the sale. The captain undertakes to free Xury after ten years if he becomes a Christian, and Xury is represented as willing to go with him. This is not simply an unconditional ten-year contract of service; freedom is explicitly tied to conversion.

The episode reveals how readily the rescued European can become a seller of another human being. The boy's consent, as the narrative presents it, softens the transaction without removing its inequality. Crusoe's former enslavement does not produce a general rejection of slavery. He distinguishes his own desire for freedom from the economic advantages he can obtain through the dependence of others.

In Brazil he establishes a plantation. Prudence, diligence, and hard work bring prosperity. Living in a Catholic society, he accommodates himself to its religious arrangements; at this stage his faith is not especially deep. The critical point is the ease with which religious affiliation can be adjusted to practical advantage. In an ironic paraphrase, his attitude might be expressed as follows: "I will accept the religion under which my business can prosper."

He later regrets selling Xury, but the regret centres on the labour he has lost: the boy would have been useful on the plantation. This exposes an instrumental attitude to other people. They appear as means to satisfy his purposes rather than as persons with purposes of their own. In the language of Kant's later moral philosophy, the problem is treating humanity merely as a means rather than also as an end.

Neighbouring planters then offer to finance a voyage to Africa to obtain enslaved workers. They know Crusoe's experience of seafaring and African trade. If he undertakes the expedition, he will receive a share of the captives without contributing capital. He accepts the offer readily. A man who knows the injustice of enslavement is prepared to organize it for his own profit. His personal suffering has not checked his acquisitiveness.

On this voyage the ship is wrecked. Within the providential pattern, the disaster can be read as chastisement for the course Crusoe has chosen. We should not, however, turn that interpretation into a claim that Defoe explicitly condemns the slave trade as such. Crusoe's own account of his sin is not a consistent abolitionist argument. The wreck removes him from society and forces him back to elementary questions of survival.

Here the central allegory comes together. A man shaped by civilization is thrown into the apparent state of nature. He must be "naturalized" by the loss of his social world, discover the basics of human life, and reconstruct a culture. In the historical metaphor

introduced earlier, individual development will recapitulate collective development. Yet the knowledge and equipment of civilization remain with him, complicating any claim that he is simply natural man.

Rebuilding Civilization on the Island

All the other members of the ship's company drown, while Crusoe survives. This gives him a further providential problem: why should he be spared when the others die? He eventually understands survival as a sign that he has been selected for a purpose. He sees himself simultaneously as sinful and as the recipient of special care. The island becomes the place where these apparently conflicting convictions must be reconciled.

His first practical response is sensible: he salvages everything he can from the wreck. Guns, powder, tools, and ironwork would be extremely difficult to reproduce alone. These objects embody the accumulated achievements of a civilization. Crusoe's apparent independence rests on resources made by others. The wreck is therefore not merely the remnant of his disaster; it is also a store of inherited capacities on which his future depends.

Over the years, he moves through a sequence that suggests the development of civilization. Hunting and gathering are followed by cultivation and animal husbandry. He learns to grow crops and domesticate goats. Each improvement responds to practical calculation. Powder is finite; reliance on hunting alone is insecure. Food production and the management of living resources make survival less dependent on supplies that cannot easily be replaced.

His prudence can seem almost excessive. A less calculating castaway might respond to catastrophe with a stiff drink; Crusoe's characteristic response is to conserve, organize, and plan. The point is not the precise quantity of liquor or powder, but the disposition these inventories reveal. He epitomizes the rational management of nature, turning immediate needs into a long-term programme of work and development.

Then comes the famous footprint in the sand. It is not identified as Friday's footprint; it belongs to an unknown visitor. Until this moment, Crusoe's problem has chiefly been his relationship with nature. Now he must confront the possibility of another human presence. The footprint transforms the island: what seemed his private domain becomes a place exposed to strangers whose intentions he cannot know.

Fear encourages him to assume danger before he knows who the stranger is. He hides, conceals signs of occupation, and takes care not to reveal himself through smoke or other traces. When he later witnesses cannibal violence, his fear acquires a visible object. Yet we should distinguish this portrayal from the sweeping assumption that all non-Western people are cannibals. That assumption is precisely the colonial stereotype this reading seeks to expose.

Crusoe rescues the man he names Friday from pursuers who intend to kill him. Friday kneels and expresses gratitude, placing himself under Crusoe's authority. Crusoe gives him a name and teaches him to call him "Master." Rescue becomes the foundation of an unequal relationship. In the critical paraphrase of the colonial ideal, the grateful dependent says, in effect: "You saved my life; I will therefore serve you."

This recalls debates about captivity and servitude in early modern political philosophy. Locke's Second Treatise of Government, published in 1689 with a 1690 title page, permits a narrow form of enslavement where an unjust aggressor has forfeited his life. It

does not authorize the enslavement of every war captive, nor does Locke think that a person can voluntarily give another absolute power over his life. These distinctions matter when invoking Locke to explain Crusoe.

Hobbes offers a different account, in which submission under the fear of death can establish a relation of dominion. Saving a captive's life may be made the basis of obedience. Such theories help us ask how apparent consent can coexist with extreme inequality. On the island, the European's possession of weapons and his power to rescue or kill give the supposed natural relationship a decidedly European advantage.

A Small Society and the Return to Europe

Another group arrives with captives, including a Spaniard and, remarkably, Friday's father. Crusoe and Friday rescue them, and the island now contains a small society. The coincidence is conspicuous: among all the people who might have appeared, the prisoner is Friday's father. Earlier, Crusoe has also dreamed of a rescue resembling the one that eventually occurs. These devices can feel contrived, even while they reinforce his providential understanding of events.

The weaknesses of the plot do not destroy the allegory. We now have Crusoe, a Protestant; Friday, whom he has instructed in Christianity; a Catholic Spaniard; and Friday's father, who retains his own religion. Crusoe describes himself as allowing liberty of conscience. The settlement brings several religious commitments together under his authority, offering an image of toleration in a world familiar with religious conflict.

This can be connected with early modern arguments against religious warfare and for toleration, including Locke's. We should not equate Crusoe's arrangement with every detail of Locke's position, which excluded Catholics and atheists from the toleration he defended. The novel's practical tolerance may also suggest indifference to doctrinal disputes. In an ironic formulation: "If God keeps providing barley, why argue about transubstantiation?" The formulation is an interpretation, not a quotation from Defoe.

The settlers consider escape, and the Spaniard and Friday's father leave to bring back other men. Before that plan is completed, an English ship appears. Mutineers bring its captain and loyal men ashore, intending to maroon them. This creates the decisive opportunity. Crusoe's caution, intelligence, and ability to plan are now directed toward a human conflict rather than simply toward the cultivation of nature.

He outwits the mutineers, releases the captain and his companions, and helps them regain control of the ship. After twenty-eight years, he has a means of returning home. In the religious structure, deliverance follows his recognition of sin and his changed understanding of providence. The practical and spiritual plots converge: the prudent worker who has learned to repent receives an opportunity to leave his exile.

Some mutineers are offered a choice: return to England, where they face punishment, or remain on the island. Crusoe leaves them houses, cultivated fields, goats, tools, and knowledge of the settlement. In a providential paraphrase, their predicament may have a purpose just as his did. He can therefore extend mercy rather than insist on their destruction. The island becomes a place in which other Europeans may continue his work.

This mercy invites comparison with the violence directed against the threatening outsiders. Europeans who have committed serious wrongdoing can be allowed another

chance. People represented as alien and dangerous face a different presumption. The novel does not maintain a perfectly simple division, but the contrast exposes a question about whose humanity is recognized and under what conditions. The Christian language of compassion exists alongside colonial hierarchy.

On returning, Crusoe discovers that his Brazilian property has produced substantial wealth while he was absent. The people who managed his affairs are represented as diligent and honest. Rather than keeping what they could have claimed after his presumed death, they acknowledge his rights and help restore his fortune. The commercial world rewards him: property, productive management, and trustworthy associates combine to make him rich.

The analogy with compound interest captures the pleasure of wealth increasing during absence, but plantation profits should not be confused with interest alone. The broader point is accumulation without the owner’s continuous personal labour. Crusoe returns to find the material reward for prudence and property ownership. The ending resembles the restoration at the close of Job: suffering is followed by renewed prosperity, although the moral questions are not thereby resolved.

There is also a European episode involving wolves, a bear, and the dangers of travel. I find it digressive; from an editorial point of view, it can seem detached from the main island narrative. Such awkwardness should be distinguished from the central achievement. Defoe’s capacity to embody a cultural outlook remains impressive even if the novel’s structure is not always economical or polished.

Crusoe rewards those who have helped him and cared for his property. They receive their share of his good fortune. He then marries and has three children, but the wife herself remains almost invisible in the narrative. The business of restoring fortunes receives much more attention than the emotional life of marriage. The disproportion supports the argument that ordinary familial attachment has little place in this particular model of the hero.

After his wife’s death, he sails again and revisits the island. One might wonder why a man who has survived twenty-eight years of isolation would want to risk another voyage. Yet the appetite for adventure and possession returns. The colony is now his property in his own account; he distributes land while reserving ownership. The people who live there participate in an order whose authority he assumes the right to define.

This raises the colonial question of natural right. European labour and occupation are made to support ownership, while the claims of people who preceded or visited the settlement receive less recognition. Crusoe becomes proprietor as well as ruler. The history of individual survival ends in a miniature colonial enterprise. Defoe’s sequel, The Further Adventures of Robinson Crusoe, also published in 1719, extends that story beyond the original island experience.

Feeling, Labour, and the Isolated Individual

Charles Dickens objected to the lack of tenderness and sentiment in the treatment of Friday’s death in the sequel. His own fiction frequently makes the suffering of vulnerable people intensely affecting, sometimes to the point of sentimentality. The contrast illuminates Defoe’s narrative economy. The objection concerns the treatment of emotion, especially when a longstanding companion is violently lost.

Friday is killed by arrows during an attack near the ship, and Crusoe explicitly describes his grief. The scene is nevertheless brief compared with what a novelist like Dickens might have made of the death of such a companion. I imagine that Dickens would have written a far longer scene and left scarcely a reader dry-eyed. The critical issue is the space granted to feeling, not its complete absence.

Marriage, children, bereavement, and companionship are often compressed, while practical arrangements expand into detailed accounts. This imbalance gives Crusoe a peculiar emotional temperature. The same figure who carefully inventories objects does not give comparable narrative attention to every human relationship. That is one reason he can seem a cold hero, even though a literal description of him as entirely without feeling would misrepresent the text.

Another philosophical implication concerns labour and value. Locke's account of property connects appropriation with labour: working on what nature provides helps to establish a claim to it. This should be distinguished from the later labour theories of value developed in political economy, including those associated with Smith, Ricardo, and Marx. A theory of how property is justified is not identical to a theory of how the value of commodities is determined.

Crusoe's inventories and records make him a natural figure for these debates. In Capital, Marx imagines him keeping an account of useful objects, activities, and the labour time required for them. The discussion concerns the relations between labour and the production of useful things. It is a theoretical use of Crusoe, not proof that Marx despised the novel or that Defoe had already formulated Marx's theory of value.

A solitary person cannot buy and sell with himself, so the island initially lacks an exchange economy. It does not lack economic problems. Crusoe must allocate limited time and resources among competing tasks, decide what is worth making, and prevent waste. Work has to be organized even in the absence of a market. This distinction helps explain both the appeal and the limitations of using an isolated castaway as an economic model.

The novel also challenges older ways of identifying the basic unit of social life. In Aristotle's account, the household is a fundamental association, while the complete political community is the polis. Crusoe's island directs our attention instead toward the apparently self-sufficient individual. He seems able to reconstruct a society by himself. The family is not the starting point, and reproduction is not necessary to the immediate organization of his world.

This helps explain why women are so marginal to the novel. The heroic experiment has been organized around an atomized male individual, not around a household or a continuing community. One person is made to stand for social development. This does not mean that all Enlightenment thinkers rejected families; it identifies a tendency in the model that Crusoe embodies. His isolation makes that tendency unusually visible.

His life can consequently be read as an image of the alienation of the bourgeois individual: an ego oriented toward acquiring, consuming, and finding opportunities, with comparatively few sustained ties to a community. He is, metaphorically, his own community. Why depend on others if one can repeat the whole development of civilization alone? The question exposes the ambition of the model, but the salvaged tools also expose its dependence on an inherited social world.

Theodicy as a Balance Sheet

One of the most revealing passages concerns theodicy in the form of a balance sheet. Crusoe asks how he should understand his circumstances and draws up opposing columns of evil and good. The procedure resembles the habits of a commercial mind: list the disadvantages, list the advantages, and see what conclusion the account permits. A question about providence is approached through a kind of moral bookkeeping.

The following are paraphrases of his contrasts. On the adverse side, he is stranded on a terrible, desolate island, apparently without hope of rescue. On the favourable side, he is alive, whereas the others have drowned. He has been singled out for misery, but he has also been singled out to escape death. The power that preserved him once may yet deliver him from his present condition.

He lacks adequate clothing, but the climate is warm enough to make clothing less necessary. He is separated from human society, but he has not been left wholly without means of subsistence. His relation to the wreck and its supplies offers further grounds for gratitude. Each complaint can be answered by another feature of the same circumstances. The exercise is meant to discipline despair and cultivate a more balanced judgment.

In the ironic language of the lecture, God finishes “in the black.” There is a positive balance, so providence can be vindicated. That is not a literal numerical calculation in the novel, but an interpretation of its commercial form of reasoning. I find it a strikingly practical and material account of theodicy. It makes divine justice resemble an assessment of benefits and losses in a well-kept ledger.

The contrast with Rousseau’s admiration is worth considering. A book that he values for education through necessity and usefulness can also encourage a rather narrow view of moral and religious life. These are not incompatible judgments; they concern different aspects of the same work. Crusoe’s practical intelligence can be admirable while the reduction of wider questions to personal advantage remains troubling.

The novel does not confine theodicy to this balance sheet. When Crusoe teaches Friday Christianity, Friday asks a devastatingly simple question: if God is stronger than the devil, why does he not destroy the devil? Why should evil persist if the power to eliminate it exists? This is Friday’s question in paraphrase, and it puts pressure on the confident religious explanations of his teacher.

Crusoe is surprised and initially pretends not to have heard. Friday repeats the question. Crusoe later attempts an answer through judgment and repentance, but his first reaction reveals how ill-prepared he is for the difficulty. He can explain some events as punishment or reward, yet that does not resolve the larger problem. Like Job’s friends, he can offer reasons without possessing a complete understanding of providence.

Friday’s question is fair and legitimate. The man presumed to need instruction identifies a difficulty that his European instructor cannot easily answer. This complicates the hierarchy of civilized teacher and dependent pupil. The novel’s attempt to vindicate providence therefore contains a moment that unsettles its own assurances. The religious alliance with practical reason remains incomplete, however confident Crusoe’s bookkeeping may appear.

The Wreck and Our Inheritance

The overall significance of Robinson Crusoe lies in the figure of Enlightenment man and his relations to nature and the wider world. Domination of nature is one of the central projects he embodies. His encounters with other societies reveal the accompanying colonial ambitions and moral contradictions. These are powerful reasons to take the novel seriously, beyond its reputation as an exciting story of survival.

I would also like to move beyond the novel and ask what one of its images might suggest about our own condition. The wrecked ship has always seemed to me an arresting image of our relationship with biblical religion. In a culture where many intellectuals find that tradition increasingly difficult to take seriously, we may feel cast into a world in which inherited forms of orientation no longer carry us as they once did.

Crusoe’s ship is grounded on a reef and will never sail again. Yet it contains things of enormous value. He would be foolish to abandon it without salvaging what he can. Its contents have taken generations to develop; they are the accumulated products of knowledge, skill, and collective experience. The fact that the vessel can no longer fulfil its original function does not make everything aboard it useless.

Something similar may be true of our religious inheritance. Even those who cannot inhabit it in its former form should consider what ought to be preserved before letting it go. It contains accumulated wisdom that cannot be recreated instantly by an isolated individual. To ignore that inheritance or discard it carelessly may leave us poorer in resources for understanding and living. This is one possible moral of the shipwreck, rather than a conclusion the novel explicitly states.

For me, the wreck is therefore one of the novel’s most compelling images. Robinson Crusoe is an important statement about the culture of the Enlightenment, but it may also tell us something about the world in which we live: about independence and inheritance, mastery and dependence, and the things we should save when an old vessel no longer carries us.